The most striking changes: Patel and Tatkare being dropped as national working president and state president, respectively. Tatkare has held on to his post, though his February re-election, too, is in a legal grey zone with a functionary from the rival camp challenging it. Stirring the pot, poll strategist-turned-Jan Suraaj Party president Prashant Kishor arrived on the scene on August 6, days after his triumph over the BJP at Bankipur in Bihar. His closed-door meeting with Sunetra and her increasingly visible son Parth led to renewed speculation that Tatkare would be replaced. That was reportedly Kishor's precondition for a strategic rebuilding of the party.

PARTH'S CHARIOT

On his part, Tatkare said he was unaware of Kishor's locus standi as advisor. He credited the party's good showing in the 2024 assembly election to ground strength rather than any outside brains trust. Parth, now national general secretary and a Rajya Sabha MP, has a certain centrality in all this. Sunetra's leadership is seen partly as a regency meant to safeguard dynastic succession, with critics saying Parth seems "in a hurry to take control of the party".

But Tatkare's bid at overlordship also meets with sharp rebukes from family loyalists, who critique him for "taunting" (Parth) rather than supporting him. Even NCP chief spokesperson Unmesh Patil launched a veiled broadside, claiming those who had been groomed and promoted by Ajit were now "creating an atmosphere causing mental anguish to Dada's family".

A party veteran says an organisational and cabinet reshuffle is likely, with the Pawars gunning for the old guard. Calling out "top-down decision-making", he notes the existential threat from Shiv Sena deputy CM Eknath Shinde, "who may choose to encroach on our turf". "The party is poised at a make-or-break point," admits another NCP leader. In his view, the future depends on whether the rival factions can reunite. But too many variables seem to be in play for such a facile solution. ■

▶ GUJARAT

COMMON POVERTY VS COMMONWEALTH

Ahmedabad cracks human trafficking trails behind the homeless on its streets, activists cite lapses

By **Jumana Shah**

WHITE SHEETS HANGING ALONG THE ROADSIDE—masking slums and poverty—have been the usual band-aid for India ahead of high-profile international dos. But Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar are sprucing up for the 2030 Commonwealth Games, with Olympic dreams hanging on that. White sheets won't cut it. So, in April, the state embarked on the mission of clearing Ahmedabad's streets of beggars and homeless people. Till now, it has 'rescued' 467 people—174 children, 188 men and 105 women. But taking them off the streets is perhaps the easiest part of the challenge. What happens after the rescue will determine whether the campaign transforms lives or stays cosmetic.

Some 150 of those 174 children were contacted in a three-day special drive in the last week of June, according to data shared by the Ahmedabad municipal corporation (AMC). The joint operation brought together the police's anti-human trafficking unit (AHTU) with the departments of social justice as well as women and child development. "We have identified 126 spots where beggars are found, including traffic signals, temples, hospitals, commercial hubs, etc. These drives will continue till CWG 2030 and after," says Mitesh Shah, who heads the AMC's department for urban community development (UCD).

Begging is not an offence under any central law, but around 20 states, including Gujarat, as well as two Union territories criminalise it

GARIBI HATAO Ahmedabad's homeless number 100,000 as per unofficial counts



AFP